

**Dan Egan**

Chapters 1–2

WEEK 1 · MON 14 SEP

WATER QUESTION**What is your favorite body of water?**

Lake Winnebago. My grandpa ice fishes on it. Also it is why I thought for years that all lakes were brown.

ARCHIVING What is here? Facts, ideas, style highlights.

Ch 1 - canals. Erie 1825, 363 mi, 40 ft wide. Welland 1829, 40 wooden locks. Seaway opens 1959, locks 766 x 80 ft - already too small when container ships show up a few yrs later. Ballast tanks carry live things in.

Ch 2 - lake trout = top predator. Lampreys come thru the Welland + wipe them out. Lamprey poison found 1957, first tried on a creek near Cheboygan MI "with almost the secrecy of a nuclear project." Superior under control by 1961. Still ~\$20 mil/yr.

STYLE: Applegate calls a creek full of dead lamprey a "real purty sight."

Egan quotes Leopold on the "wolfless mountain" - borrowed authority?

ANALYZING What does it mean? Who cares, who doesn't, who should care?

The numbers are doing a job. He stacks up canal stats before he says anything you could actually argue with, so by the lamprey chapter you already trust him.

Who cares: fishermen, the states, whoever pays the poison bill. Who doesn't: the shipping companies - they got their door open and left. Who should: anyone downstream, and the people who were already here. Two chapters on these lakes and no Anishinaabe yet, which seems like a choice and not an oversight.

Also every fix in ch 2 is one more intervention. Poison to fix a canal.

EXTENDING What does this tell us about our world right here and now?

We do this constantly. Build the shortcut, then pay forever to manage what came through it. \$20 million a year is not a solution, it is rent.

The Fox River is 20 min from here and I have never once thought about what is in it or where it ends up. Egan's whole point is that the connection is the danger, and I live on one end of it.

DISCUSSION What helpful questions can we ask about this work?

Who decided the Seaway was worth it, and did anyone downstream get a vote?

Why does he tell the Noah's flood story like it is settled science?

Is there a version of "fixing" the lakes that is not another intervention?

VOCABULARY WORDS

lampricide · ballast · apex predator
lock · draft · parasite · basin

FEELINGS EVOKED

Wants awe first (megaflood, Niagara), then dread once the door is open, then grief for the trout. On me: suspicion.

